

Advanced Excel Training: Pre-Course Assessment And Needs Survey

Purpose

This assessment helps confirm participant readiness, identify training needs, and tailor the 2-day Advanced Excel session to the team's real work.

Suggested format:

- Microsoft Forms or Google Forms.
- 10-15 minutes to complete.
- Mix of self-rating, multiple choice, and short answer.

Section 1: Participant Information

1. Full name
2. Job title
3. Department
4. Main role:
 - FP&A
 - Sales analysis
 - Accounting
 - Production analysis
 - Other
5. How often do you use Excel?
 - Daily
 - Several times per week
 - Weekly
 - Occasionally

Section 2: Excel Version And Access

1. Which version of Excel do you use most often?
 - Microsoft 365
 - Excel 2021
 - Excel 2019
 - Excel 2016 or older
 - Not sure

2. Do you have access to Power Query?

- Yes
- No
- Not sure

3. Do you have access to Power Pivot or the Data Model?

- Yes
- No
- Not sure

4. Are macros/VBA allowed in your organization?

- Yes
- No
- Not sure

Section 3: Self-Assessment

Rate your ability from 1 to 5:

1 = Not confident

2 = Basic

3 = Working knowledge

4 = Strong

5 = Advanced

1. Cleaning messy data
2. Building formulas
3. Using PivotTables
4. Creating charts
5. Building dashboards
6. Using lookup formulas
7. Using Power Query
8. Building financial or operational models
9. Performing variance analysis
10. Explaining insights from data
11. Auditing formulas and finding errors
12. Automating repetitive Excel tasks

Section 4: Practical Knowledge Check

These questions help identify current level. They are not meant to embarrass anyone.

1. Which formula would you most likely use to return a value from another table based on a matching ID?

- SUM

- XLOOKUP
- ROUND
- CONCAT

2. Which tool is best for summarizing thousands of rows by month, category, and department?

- PivotTable
- Spell Check
- Freeze Panes
- Page Layout

3. What is the main benefit of using an Excel Table?

- It makes the file larger
- It allows structured references and expands automatically
- It removes all formulas
- It prevents filtering

4. Which tool is best for cleaning and transforming recurring data files before reporting?

- Power Query
- WordArt
- Cell Styles
- Print Preview

5. What does IFERROR help with?

- Hiding worksheets
- Managing formula errors gracefully
- Printing a workbook
- Sorting dates

6. What is a good practice in a financial model?

- Put assumptions, calculations, and outputs anywhere
- Hardcode all results
- Separate inputs, calculations, outputs, and checks
- Hide all formulas

7. Which method would you use to test how profit changes at different sales growth rates?

- Sensitivity analysis
- Remove duplicates
- Freeze panes
- Format painter

8. What is the purpose of a reconciliation or check line in a workbook?

- To make the file look complex

- To confirm totals agree and reduce error risk
- To change the font
- To delete old data

Section 5: Work Context

1. What types of Excel files do you use most often?

- Budgets
- Forecasts
- Sales reports
- Production reports
- Inventory reports
- Financial statements
- Payroll or expense reports
- Dashboards
- Other

2. What are your biggest Excel challenges?

- Cleaning data
- Formulas
- PivotTables
- Dashboards
- Forecasting
- Variance analysis
- Errors and audit checks
- Slow manual reporting
- Presenting insights
- Other

3. What repetitive Excel task would you like to make faster?

4. What report or analysis do you wish you could improve?

5. What would make this training valuable for you?

Section 6: Topic Interest

Select your top 5 topics:

- Advanced formulas
- XLOOKUP and lookup logic
- Dynamic array formulas
- PivotTables and PivotCharts
- Power Query

- Power Pivot / Data Model
- Dashboards
- Budgeting and forecasting
- Variance analysis
- Scenario and sensitivity analysis
- Financial modelling
- Sales analysis
- Production analysis
- Accounting reports
- Data cleaning
- Error checking and audit techniques
- Automation

Section 7: Prerequisite Confirmation

1. I can create basic formulas in Excel.
 - Yes
 - Somewhat
 - No
2. I can sort and filter data.
 - Yes
 - Somewhat
 - No
3. I can work with basic Excel reports.
 - Yes
 - Somewhat
 - No
4. I am comfortable bringing a laptop and completing hands-on exercises.
 - Yes
 - No

Suggested Scoring Guide

Use the knowledge check to group participants:

- 0-3 correct: Needs foundation support before advanced tools.
- 4-6 correct: Ready for intermediate-to-advanced training.
- 7-8 correct: Strong candidate for advanced exercises and stretch tasks.

Use self-assessment averages: